

**SWINBURNE VIETNAM
ALLIANCE PROGRAM**



Artisan Digital Literacy in Kien Giang A Case Study

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Part A

1.1 Project Overview

The project “E-commerce Platforms for Traditional Handicrafts from Southern Vietnam” is integrated into the course “Technology in an Indigenous Context Project”, allowing students not only to discover and immerse themselves in different customs and cultures but also to implement cutting-edge technologies and tools to support the economic empowerment and cultural preservation of diverse artisan communities, particularly indigenous and ethnic minority groups across Southern Vietnam. Moreover, the Request for Proposal (RFP) figures out the significant role of traditional handicrafts in sustaining livelihoods, preserving rich cultural heritage, and transmitting ancestral skills. Consequently, the interesting project aims to expand professional market both nationally and internationally, enhance digital literacy level, and overcome difficulties by developing and implementing culturally appropriate and community-managed e-commerce platforms. Finally, the project fosters fair trade practices, ensures community ownership, promotes cultural iconic, and strives for the long-term sustainability of artisan livelihoods.

1.2 Introduction to Problems

First and foremost, traditional handicraft artisan communities and villages across Southern Vietnam, specifically those comprising Indigenous and minority ethnic groups, deal with several critical challenges. Therefore, limited market access and low digital literacy restrict them to local sales and prevent the expansion of professional partnerships, hindering their ability to engage with online commerce nationally and internationally. Furthermore, these hard-working artisans also struggle with integrating secure payment and efficient logistics solutions, ensuring accurate and respectful cultural representation and fair pricing remains difficult. Consequently, without effective e-commerce solutions, these communities risk losing economic opportunities and the ability to preserve their valuable traditional skills and cultural heritage.

Part B

2.1 Description

According to the *Phase I* specifications outlined in the detailed document, the e-commerce platforms should be designed to establish culturally sensitive and well-informed foundations. Furthermore, the primary objective of these platforms is extensive engagement with diverse artisan communities to comprehensively understand their current market challenges, digital literacy levels, and specific requirements for online engagement. In addition, this phase ensures that the subsequent platform strategy and technical requirements are collaboratively defined, ethically guided, and truly reflective of the communities' preferences, fostering a framework built on their unique context and long-term sustainability.

Following *Phase I*, *Phase II* demands technical creation and refinement of the e-commerce platforms, involving designing intuitive and user-friendly interfaces tailored for both artisans (for product listing, order management) and customers (for browsing, purchasing), with careful consideration for varying levels of digital literacy. Therefore, core activities include the robust development of secure e-commerce platforms based on defined technical requirements, seamless integration of secure payment gateways, and the establishment of efficient logistics and shipping solutions. In addition, the interfaces are mandated to feature comprehensive multi-language support, primarily Vietnamese and English, and to be fully optimized for both website and mobile responsiveness. In essence, *Phase II* aims not only to deliver sustainable and functional interfaces with

diverse categories and features but also to effectively showcase unique traditional artifacts, highlight their profound historical significance, and ultimately facilitate the ongoing preservation of cultural heritage.

2.2 Contextual Background: Kien Giang Province and its Artisan Villages

Kien Giang Province, located in Southern Vietnam's Mekong Delta region, is a hidden gem renowned for its stunning blue ocean, pristine white sands, and picturesque islands that offer unique and immersive experiences for visitors. Beyond its natural beauty, the province also contains a rich tapestry of traditional artisan communities and their unique handicrafts, which strongly showcase cultural preservation and serve as an iconic representation of the country's heritage. During Phase I, team members identified two outstanding provinces: Dong Thap and Kien Giang Province. After considering both external and internal factors including available materials, natural resources, digital literacy level overall, and tourism potential, leading to the selection of Kien Giang Province as the primary focus for the project's implementation. Consequently, traditional artisan villages are renowned for their unique local products that reflect the region's rich cultural heritage.

Kien Giang Province's robust and growing economy further solidifies its position as an ideal location for the project's next phases. Moreover, the province demonstrated strong economic vitality with a notable growth rate of 7.05% in the third quarter of 2024. Additionally, Kien Giang has set ambitious targets, aiming for an industrial production value of \$2.52 billion by 2025, reflecting a projected 13.28% increase in industrial production value this year. As a result, this dynamic economic environment, coupled with its rich cultural heritage and tourism potential, makes Kien Giang a strategic and promising choice for the project's implementation. especially considering its renowned traditional artisan villages and their unique products.

For example, Thanh Hung rice paper is cherished for its distinctive fragrance and flexibility, and Phu My rice crackers is known for their unique taste, aroma, and richness, particularly the milk and sesame-flavored varieties. Therefore, the sepcific province also boasts Ha Tien dried shrimp, prized for its unique flavor and long shelf life. Beyond these culinary delights, artisans create beautiful handicrafts such as hats woven from leaves, intricate bamboo woven baskets and mats, and durable grass woven mats, all showcasing the depth of traditional craftsmanship in Kien Giang. In summary, the significant combination between natural splendor and profound cultural depth positions Kien Giang as an ideal setting to implement initiatives aimed at empowering local artisans. Hence, by implementing advanced technologies and tools, team believes that this application can unlock new market opportunities for these cherished traditional products, ultimately contributing to the sustainable development and cultural enrichment of the entire province.

Kien Giang province is actively promoting investment for 2025, with a strong focus on attracting high-technology projects and integrating into global supply chains. Additonaly, the province prioritizes environmentally friendly ventures that offer high added value and efficient land use. Specifically, Kien Giang is targeting key international partners, particularly from leading countries in global supply chains like the United States, Canada, the EU, Singapore, Australia, and New Zealand. Furthermore, the province is seeking out to develop new industrial sectors such as semiconductors, hydrogen, science and technology, and innovation. In addition, the investment promotion program aims for a 10% increase in registered capital in 2025 compared to 2024. Hence, Kien Giang is committed to supporting businesses by providing access to information, markets, technology, and land, while continuously striving to improve its business environment and enhance competitiveness to ensure attractiveness for investors. Currently, Kien Giang has attracted 748 projects spanning 31,720 hectares, with a total registered investment capital of VND588,725.61 billion.

2.3 The Profound history of Kien Giang Province

Kien Giang Province is home to diverse traditional handicraft villages and communities that embody national identity and contribute significantly to cultural preservation. Moreover, the burgeoning tourism sector has opened new avenues for these traditional crafts, enabling artisans to directly showcase their skills to visitors and market their products. Additionally, the integration of cutting-edge technologies and tools facilitates workshops and interactive demonstrations, enabling tourists to directly engage in the craft-making process, thereby fostering a deeper appreciation for the artisans' skills and cultural heritage. In contrast, maintaining the delicate balance between upholding tradition and ensuring commercial viability remains a pivotal challenge, as artisans strive to preserve authentic techniques while concurrently adapting to evolving market demands and the increasing competition from mass-produced goods. Even as the twenty-first century unfolds, Kien Giang Province retains a profound historical significance, distinguishing it among other regions across Southern Vietnam.

Beyond these revered craft villages and communities, the Phu Quoc Fish Sauce Village represents a paramount example, boasting a profound history spanning approximately 200 years. Its establishment is intricately linked to the island's abundant fishing grounds, where the plentiful supply of anchovies provided the foundational resource for this iconic condiment. Over two centuries, the villagers have refined a distinct fermentation process, employed large wooden vats and strictly adhered to time-honored methods, which collectively contribute to the sauce's renowned aroma and flavor. Notably, the village transcends the role of a mere production site; it functions as a living museum, showcasing a traditional craft that has not only sustained countless livelihoods but has also elevated Phu Quoc fish sauce to a globally recognized Protected Designation of Origin (PDO) product, symbolizing the deep-seated heritage and dedication of Kien Giang's artisans. In summary, the Phu Quoc Fish Sauce Village serves as a quintessential example of Kien Giang Province's rich artisan heritage, demonstrating how centuries of traditional practices, deeply rooted in local resources, have led to the creation of a globally acclaimed PDO product, thereby solidifying the province's cultural identity.

2.4 Artisan Communities and Villages Background

The artisan communities and villages in Kien Giang Province represent a vibrant cross-section of Vietnam's cultural heritage incl skills and traditions passed down through generations. For instance, Thanh Hung rice paper artisans, renowned for delicate, pliable sheets valued for taste and texture. Similarly, Phu My rice cracker makers excel at producing rich, aromatic snacks, especially the popular milk and sesame varieties. In coastal Ha Tien, dried shrimp artisans are known for meticulous drying methods that yield flavorful, long-lasting products. Inland, leaf hat weavers, bamboo basket makers, and grass mat artisans continue to thrive, blending utility with intricate craftsmanship. Specifically, this great combination of implementing outstanding technologies with traditional handicrafts presents a significant opportunity to not only enhance the province's economy but also ensure the sustainable preservation of its unique cultural heritage and elevate the livelihoods of its artisan communities.

According to VietNameNews, Ho Van Tai, an artisan from Đồng Tháp, is recognized as the sole remaining practitioner of embossed fabric picture art in southern Vietnam, a craft he has dedicated 68 years to. This distinctive art form, originating in 1948 by Trần Văn Huy, integrates painting with textile manipulation to produce three-dimensional imagery. Its creation involves meticulous steps: sketching, shaping with cotton, enveloping in fabric, and affixing to a painted canvas. Despite its popularity between 1956 and 1965, the craft is now declining due to reduced demand and a lack of new practitioners, with only Tai and his wife continuing the tradition. Tai, who has produced over 3,000 pieces, voices concerns regarding the craft's potential disappearance and seeks to culminate his legacy with a final exhibition.

2.5 Artisan Digitalization

Kiên Giang Province in Vietnam is developing its handicraft industry by utilizing dried water hyacinths, which are abundant in the Mekong Delta Region. Notably, residents in rural areas are transforming these dried stems into a variety of products such as baskets, hats, and carpets, providing a stable income and contributing to poverty reduction. Significantly, the formation of cooperative groups and weaving clubs has further enhanced sales and increased participation, leading to improved livelihoods for many. Furthermore, the provincial People's Committee has officially recognized water hyacinth product making as a traditional occupation and plans to further support its development through technological advancements, soft loans, and collaborations with companies to ensure stable sales and enhance product value.

Vietnam is actively pursuing digital transformation, exemplified by the initiatives in the Nguyen Thai Binh community in Kien Giang province. Therefore, a central pillar of these efforts is the enhancement of digital literacy, spearheaded by a five-member community digital technology team. Moreover, this team provides hands-on training to residents on various digital applications, aiming for at least one person in every household to be proficient in using smartphone technology. Additionally, local leadership and party members also play a vital role, with each assigned to support multiple households in mastering digital skills. Hence, significant progress has been noted, with approximately 300 individuals guided to install electronic identification and digital social insurance applications since January 2023. As a result, community-based approach directly addresses the digital literacy landscape, bridging the digital divide by empowering citizens with practical digital skills and serving as a crucial conduit for disseminating government policies on digital transformation.

2.6 Research Design and Methods

The “Research Design and Methods” demonstrates the comprehensive Integrated Research and Deliberation Approach adopted by the project team, which underpinned the successful execution of this case study on artisan digital literacy in Kien Giang Province. Notably, the methodology extended beyond conventional data collection, emphasizing a rigorous, systematic, and highly collaborative process. During the project, team members actively participated in researching relevant literature and best practices, meticulously gathering both primary and secondary data, and thoroughly analyzing findings to identify key patterns and insights. Specifically, the analytical phase was complemented by extensive discussions among the team, fostering a collective synthesis of information and diverse perspectives. Consequently, this important iterative cycle of inquiry and deliberation culminated in the ability to make informed and actionable final decisions, ensuring that all conclusions and recommendations were robustly evidence-based and collaboratively derived.

2.7 Digital Literacy Landscape & Challenges

The digital literacy landscape in the Kien Giang Province is uneven, mirroring Vietnam's broader rural-urban disparities. While younger generations exhibit moderate familiarity with modern digital platforms such as Zalo and Facebook, older and rural traditional artisans largely possess limited digital proficiency. As a result, undamental tasks such as online listing creation, e-commerce management, or digital marketplace navigation remain challenging. Hence, limited formal training, insufficient access to affordable devices, and inadequate internet connectivity in remote areas further impede digital adoption. Furthermore, cultural hesitancy and concerns about technology supplanting tradition also foster resistance in certain communities. However, a nascent willingness to adopt digital tools is evident among some artisan groups, particularly when directly linked to economic enhancement or tourism development.

The launch of the Centre for Monitoring Cyber Security and Safety in Kien Giang Province marks a significant step towards enhancing digital literacy and cybersecurity awareness among its residents. Therefore, part of a

broader digital government strategy, aims to improve administrative efficiency and public service quality. By investing approximately VNĐ16 billion (around \$690,000), the center will not only safeguard information but also facilitate data analysis to support informed decision-making in socio-economic development. The integration of advanced technologies such as big data and artificial intelligence will further empower local authorities to manage resources effectively and respond to community needs promptly. Consequently, this proactive approach to cybersecurity is essential in fostering a digitally literate society that can navigate the complexities of the digital age safely and responsibly.

In addition to cybersecurity advancements, Kien Giang Province is also transforming its educational landscape through digital initiatives like the KAV Open School, aiming to enhance educational access and quality by leveraging digital tools and resources. By implementing technology in education, the province is not only preparing students for a future that increasingly relies on digital skills but also ensuring that learning is more accessible and engaging. In addition, the focus on digital literacy within the educational framework is crucial, as it equips students with the necessary skills to thrive in a technology-driven world. As these initiatives unfold, they promise to create a more informed and capable citizenry, ready to contribute to the province's socio-economic growth in the digital era.

2.8 Design Approaches for Digital Literacy Enhancements

In Kien Giang Province, the integration of digital technologies encounters a notable generational divide, manifesting as distinct levels of digital literacy among its population. While the younger generation adapts quickly to and exhibits proficiency with outstanding technological applications and tools for complex tasks, older and traditional artisan communities and villages frequently have limited digital access, leading to limited market reach nationally and internationally and hindering the expansion of professional trading relationships. Additionally, most individuals effectively utilize basic communication platforms including Zalo and Facebook for daily conversations and social interaction. As a result, based on the project requirements, the team has decided to implement the 'Artisan Community Interface' to address these challenges, allowing artisans to seamlessly showcase their iconic products, connect with a wider customer base, receive training on e-commerce, and manage sales, thereby bridging the digital divide and fostering economic growth within their communities. Consequently, this solution and approach will significantly boost the livelihoods of traditional artisans, preserve cultural heritage by expanding the market for their crafts, and contribute to the overall socio-economic development of Kien Giang Province.

In addition, the fascinating interface after my team generates and launches offers diverse categories including News, Training, Resources, Collaboration, Support, and Logistics categories that announce the latest and highlight news relevant to the artisan community, provide essential training modules, offer valuable resources for business development, facilitate collaboration among artisans, deliver crucial support services, and streamline logistics for product distribution respectively. Therefore, the team believes that this approach not only bridges the existing digital divide but also fosters sustainable economic growth, empowers artisans with vital skills, and ensures the long-term preservation of Kien Giang's unique cultural heritage.

2.9 Impacts and Benefits of E-Commerce platforms on Kien Giang province

The implementation of e-commerce platforms in the project “E-Commerce Platforms for Traditional Handicrafts from Southern Vietnam” allows artisans from various Southern Vietnamese provinces, particularly Kien Giang Province, to transcend geographical barriers and access broader national and international markets, thereby significantly boosting their economic viability and preserving unique cultural heritage. For example, Phu Quoc fish sauce producers can directly market their globally recognized GI product, while artisans from Gò Quao and Vĩnh Thuận districts can showcase their eco-friendly water hyacinth handicrafts, and Phu My weaving village can bring its intricate sedge mats to a wider audience. As a result, this expansion is crucial for boosting the livelihoods of these artisan communities, offering new revenue streams and potentially leading to higher income stability. Furthermore, the provision of e-commerce training and sales management tools within

these platforms will significantly enhance the digital literacy of older generations, fostering a more digitally inclusive society. In summary, digital integration stimulates broader socio-economic development, serving as a vital catalyst for sustainable growth and cultural preservation.

2.10 Conclusion

In conclusion, participating in the project 'E-Commerce Platforms for Traditional Handicrafts from Southern Vietnam' in the course 'Technology in an Indigenous Context – COS10025' has provided invaluable practical experience in applying technology to address real-world challenges, directly contributing to the economic empowerment and cultural preservation of traditional artisan communities in Southern Vietnam. Therefore, engaging in this exciting project not only enhances soft skills that are important for academic performance and a future career, such as teamwork and critical thinking, but also allows us to discover and immerse ourselves in different artisan communities and villages with iconic and traditional products. Moreover, implementing e-commerce platforms serves as a vital catalyst for sustainable economic growth, ensuring the long-term viability of traditional livelihoods and celebrating the unique cultural narratives embedded within each handcrafted item.

Part C

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